

Open Source for Professionals

There are many open source options available for professionals to help them in their complex tasks. The tools mentioned here come mainly in two forms – as an offline installation, or as a web service and accessible over a browser. To strike a balance, we have covered just a few in brief and offered links to a whole lot more for the inquisitive professional to look up.

While there surely is a bias towards Linux when it comes to open source, there are a few Windows-only applications. The selection of an application to review has also been influenced by the relative lack of awareness about Linux installation procedures among the general population. The Windows user can take comfort in the fact that since these Linux only applications are open source, the source code will be available and can be compiled for Windows (compiling instructions are not provided here). It needs to be noted that in the case of the very few Windows-only applications, sometimes their dependence on proprietary libraries such as the .NET framework make it impossible to run them in Linux. Emulators do exist that offer middle ground – Cygwin (www.cygwin.com) for running Linux applications in Windows and Wine (www.winehq.org) to run Windows applications in Linux.

A more general case is that of Debian, a venerable Linux distro with probably the largest package database. Debian offers different *blends* of their popular distro targeted at different pros. For example, Debian Med is a *blend* containing all packages related to the medical field. *Blending* merely involves getting the packages related to the particular field, so to create a Debian Med

A word on distros

Thanks to the freedom inherent in the open source movement, it is common to find custom live Linux distros containing several packages related to a particular profession offering a complete working environment that runs off the CD/DVD. This is significantly more convenient than finding and downloading individual applications. For example, VLinux is a complete Linux distro based on Knoppix that is available as a live CD and is targeted at bio-informatics professionals. This distro is available for download at www.bioinformatics.org/vLinux/.